



CPI(M) and RSS-BJP often resort to violence to keep the ranks in the fold.

workers arrested in connection with the murders. "What happened in Thalasserry was purely political murders and, therefore, the parties have to put a halt to them. Now things are under control," says Raman Srivastava, director-general of police.

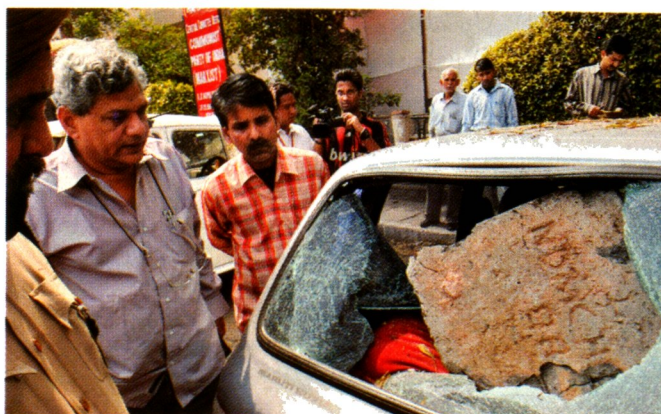
Though Congress and CPI(M) have remained the main political adversaries in the state for decades now, RSS embroiled in the tussle after the 1970s when it began making inroads into what were traditional Left bastions. The growing tendency among the young generation of many traditional communist families of embracing RSS or BJP was blasphemy, as far as the CPI(M) was concerned. For instance, former BJP state president C.K. Padmanabhan had come from a communist family of Kannur. For both CPI(M) and BJP bouts of violence have become necessary to keep the ranks in the fold. Not surprisingly, the offices and of both parties and even those of Congress are always ready for battle with stockpiles of country bombs, guns, swords and other ammunition. In fact, on three occasions district Police Superintendent K. Sreejith had to brave flying country bombs as the rival party workers fought against each other.

An increasing internal strife in BJP leading to a split

and a major drop in the number of RSS shakhas have been cited as a cause for the sudden rise in their "actions". As per a report presented in the state RSS meet in Thrissur last June, the number of shakhas in Kerala (one of the highest in the country once) has dropped from 4,500 to 3,700. The organisation was alarmed by the non-remission of the annual Vijayadashami contribution by more than 60,000 members in 2007.

Though most victims from both the political camps in Kannur are low level workers who come from poor families, several top leaders from the district too have been involved in violence. Among those killed in the past include Jayakrishnan and Panniannur Chandran who were state level BJP leaders while CPI(M) state com-

ACT OF REVENGE: Yechury inspects his car damaged in an attack on CPI(M) headquarters in Delhi



AP PHOTO

mittee members like E.P. Jayarajan and P. Jayarajan were grievously injured. "In Kannur it is the tail which wags the dog," says P.K. Gangadharan Nair, a prominent physician and social analyst from Kannur. "Leaders of both parties are under heavy pressure from lower ranks to give green signal for acts of revenge and bloodshed. There are occasions when ranks, disillusioned with leadership which block acts of revenge, leave the party."

Though the recent violence in Thalasserry was fuelled by the urge for revenge, many attribute it to the social culture of the region. "This place comes within the Kadathanadu region which is home for Kalaripayatt, the traditional Kerala martial arts. The famed folk songs of the region called Vadakkan Patt (northern ballads) are paeans to legendary warlords and celebrate physical violence," says Nair.

It's not merely a coincidence that a small Siva temple in Ponnyam—a CPI(M) party village—is named Vairi Ghataka (executioner of the enemy) and the nearby Subramonya shrine is called Porkkalam (battlefield). The numerous memorials in Kannur built for all those killed in political violence are just a grim reminder of the many bloody battles fought on this land.